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CENTRAL WASHINGTON UNIVERSITY ARCHIVES AND SPECIAL COLLECTIONS

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Tatu and Loulis are the last two surviving chimps from a series of experiments that began in the 1960s. The pair have spent their entire lives in captivity, including stints at facilities in Oklahoma and Washington, where researchers studied their ability to learn ASL—hoping to challenge the prevailing belief that only humans could use language.

Since 2013 they've been living at Fauna, where both chimpanzees continue to sign. Tatu, the more loquacious one, has mastery of 215 signs, while Loulis can use 78. Among their favorite things to talk to their caregivers about are food and activities. Tatu is partial to cheese and enjoys a nice cup of coffee or tea, while Loulis prefers asking his caregivers to play a game of chase.

Whether language is unique to humans has been a subject of fascination to linguists and scientists for centuries, and in the 1960s they began turning in earnest to one of our closest genetic relatives to finally put the question to rest. This research was pioneered by a pair of psychology professors at the

University of Nevada, Reno, the husband-and-wife couple Allen and Beatrix “Trixie” Gardner, who sought to prove that under the right circumstances chimpanzees could learn a human language.

Their research began in 1966 with an infant chimp, taken from West Africa for use in U.S. Air Force experiments, whom they adopted and named Washoe. The Gardners raised Washoe as much like a human child as possible. She learned to use a potty (which she would call “dirty good” in sign language), played with dolls, and admired the photos in magazines.

Washoe became a sensation in academia, but her fame would be surpassed in the 1970s by two other primates: Koko the gorilla and Nim Chimpsky. While the methodologies for those experiments would later come under fire, casting into doubt whether Koko and Nim understood what they were saying, the same was not true for Washoe, who ultimately developed a vocabulary of 245 words before her death in 2007 at Central Washington University.

The Gardners repeated their experiments with four more chimpanzees: Moja, who loved to paint; Dar, who enjoyed wearing hats and examining mechanical objects; Pili, a male who died from leukemia before age two; and Tatu. They eventually turned their work over to their former graduate student, Roger Fouts, and his wife, Deborah, who took in Washoe, Moja, Dar, and Tatu, as well as young Loulis, who became the first and only chimp to learn ASL from other chimps.

It’s unlikely that Tatu and Loulis are aware they were at the heart of groundbreaking scientific research, or the complex ethical questions that came with it. While the chimpanzee ASL experiments taught researchers much about how humans evolved our communication abilities, the knowledge came at a cost to the research subjects. Now in their geriatric years (chimps rarely live past 60), Tatu and Loulis will likely never again see their natural habitats in the tropical forests of West and Central Africa. Successfully introducing chimps raised in captivity to the wild is impossible. Not only do they lack the skills to survive in the wild, but they could possibly face a violent rejection from any communities of chimps they meet. Barring a transfer to another similar haven, they are almost certain to live out the rest of their days at Fauna.

That cost would eventually lead some of the same scientists who raised the chimps to develop intense moral qualms about their most famous work—and even turn against it.